

winter and then given a balanced liquid fertilizer while fruits are developing. Keep the trees well-weeded and well-watered.

THINNING

It is essential to thin out peaches and nectarines while the fruits are young. This will force the tree to focus its energy on forming larger, higher-quality peaches or nectarines. When the fruits are very small, thin to leave one fruit per cluster, removing all the others. When fruits have grown larger, thin them out again so that there is about 8–10 in (20–25 cm) between peaches and 6 in (15 cm) between nectarines—the space they need to grow to their full size.

HARVESTING

Peaches and nectarines are ready to harvest once they become soft—take care not to drop them, since they bruise and spoil easily. They are ready to pick when they pull easily away from the tree.

STORING

Once picked and fully ripened, peaches and nectarines will only last for a few days, before they go bad and begin to rot. Freeze or use to make jam if you cannot eat the fruits fast enough.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Peaches and nectarines can be afflicted by a range of problems. Creating a barrier will guard against some of them: covering with plastic sheeting reduces the risk of peach leaf curl, netting can help deter birds, and if it is very fine, wasps, too. Other problems are harder to combat:

- Aphids stunt growth and cause leaves to curl. Spray affected leaves with pyrethrin or insecticidal soap.
- Red spider mite cause leaves to appear “bronzed.” Treat as for aphids.
- Silver leaf disease causes leaves to appear silvery. Remove the damaged plant material and destroy, being careful to keep cutting tools sterilized.
- Bacterial canker causes round holes to form in leaves and gum to ooze from the bark. Treat as for silver leaf.



Aphids (left) cause leaves to curl; they may become sticky with honeydew. **Peach leaf curl (right)** causes leaves to distort and become bright red in color.